

Opinion Pooling II: Group Rationality and Responsibility

2026-02-04

Group Rationality and Justified Group Belief

Last time we discussed:

- Different responses to peer disagreement.
- The uniqueness vs. permissivism debate.
- How these relate to opinion pooling.

Today: What makes group beliefs *rational* and when are groups *responsible* for their beliefs and actions?

The Individual vs. Group Question

Recall Anya, Bon, and Carys (20%, 60%, 70% on polio eradication).

Two different questions:

1. **Individual response:** When they learn of each other's views, how should each person update their own credence?
2. **Group credence:** What credence should *the group* (as a collective agent) adopt?

These might get different answers. Today we focus on question 2.

What Are Group Credences?

Group credences from pooling are epistemic compromises, not necessarily consensus beliefs.

- Members agree to use pooled credences for group reasoning and decision-making.
- But individuals need not personally adopt those credences. (Unless a strong form of Equal Weight is true.)
- You can sign off on a committee report as genuinely being the view of the committee without agreeing with every detail.

We need rational group beliefs for:

- Collective decision-making (e.g., boards, committees);
- Scientific collaboration (e.g., research teams);
- Policy recommendations (expert panels);
- Collective action (unions, cooperatives, governments);
- Legal responsibility (corporate liability).

One theory: A particular attitude is maximally epistemically rational for a group if and only if that attitude is amongst the most effective means toward pursuing some specified epistemic goals.

This is the view Matthew Kopec (now at Harvard) suggested in his 2019 paper, and it's basically what Elkin and Pettigrew take up.

This isn't a compulsory view, and it has some downsides.

In the individual case, people often worry that sometimes believing something against the evidence might have instrumental value, e.g., having an exaggerated view of your own abilities might lead you to take on more interesting projects.

But it's what they're working with, so we'll go with it.

If rationality is about getting your epistemic goals, what are groups' epistemic goals?

Hopefully they include **getting to the truth**.

- Groups should have accurate beliefs about the world.
- This is both good in itself, and (in general) useful for achieving things.
- Both of these are true for individuals as well as groups.

But is truth enough? Can we explain everything in terms of the goal of getting to truths.

The traditional view is that rational belief requires more than truth - it requires **justification**, which usually means **evidence**.

This should apply to groups too. Whatever is wrong with lucky guesses for individuals, it seems wrong for groups.

It's hard enough for individuals to get to justified true belief.

For groups, there are a few more complications.

- Members may have different evidence;
- Members may have different background beliefs;
- Members may disagree about what counts as justification (if this matters to justification, itself a tricky process);
- Even if each individual is justified, the pooling process itself must preserve justification somehow.

Accounts of Justified Group Belief

Lackey categorizes views as:

1. **Inflationary**, i.e. Group status can float freely from members' epistemic statuses; or
2. **Deflationary**, i.e., Group status is just the aggregation of members' individual statuses.

Inflationary Accounts: The Cohesiveness View

The core idea is that group belief requires some cohesive element binding members together.

This means all the individuals sharing the belief is not enough for the group to have it, because there might not be the right kind of binding.

But conversely, the group can believe something that no individual does, and even justifiably believe something that no individual does, if they are bound together in the right way.

This is most intuitive for **practical beliefs**, that we express with knowledge how claims.

Ford Motor Company knows how to build cars, but it isn't obvious to me that any person in the company does. Cars these days are just too complicated for any one person to have that knowledge.

Tuomela defines group belief in terms of individual *acceptance*.

- “Acceptance” $\neq$ individual belief
- It’s a commitment to treat something as true *for some purpose*, in this case a group purpose.
- The idea here came out of philosophy of science, where some people think that we should treat scientists as accepting the best current theories, even though the scientist might accept that the theory is probably wrong (like all past theory).
- The kind of acceptance Tuomela cares about requires coordination.

If groups float *too* freely from members:

- A group could have justified beliefs even if no member does.
- Lackey objects that this seems to create justification out of nothing.
- So perhaps it violates intuition that justification must trace back to evidence.
- Personally, I think the Ford case is a nice response to this. Every individual has evidence about how to build gearboxes, steering systems, etc, and collectively they have evidence about how to build a **whole car**.

The idea here is that group beliefs just are properly aggregated member beliefs, and that justified group beliefs are just properly aggregated *justified* member beliefs.

- A nice upside here is that group justification derives in a natural way from member justification.
- Pooling becomes important here; it's how we combine the individual beliefs.

If group belief is just aggregation, then:

- The pooling method becomes really important.
- If we use the wrong pooling method, we might destroy justification.
- Indeed, the wrong pooling method might create false group beliefs from true individual beliefs. (Think about getting inconsistent beliefs from consistent beliefs.)
- Arguably, the pooling method itself should become the subject of epistemic evaluation.

For Elkin and Pettigrew, this motivates examining which pooling axioms preserve justification.

Let's assume that a group's beliefs should be responsive to its evidence. That seems like part of what justification is.

That raises a question: when members have the same evidence but different credences, what should the group believe?

- If uniqueness holds then most one credence is justified by the evidence.
- It's really unlikely that pooling will yield it. And if it does, it will do so kinda by chance, since some of the inputs will be irrational.
- If permissivism holds, then pooling could yield any of them, and actually it's not clear why it should pick one or the other.

Some pooling strategies are more evidence-sensitive than others.

Just adding up the numbers and dividing by n is not evidence sensitive.

But we could do some other options, such as:

- Giving experts more weight.
- Giving people with better track-records more weight. (Not always the same thing as experts.)
- Discounting outliers. (Note this is something we do after hearing the numbers.)

These are both **epistemic** and **practical** questions about how and when to do this.

Group Responsibility

The previous discussion was about what groups believed, and whether those beliefs were *epistemically rational*.

Now we'll move onto whether groups are *practically rational*, and to the conditions for groups being *morally responsible*.

The key question is when groups are answerable for their opinions and actions.

Groups make decisions that have consequences:

- Corporate boards make business decisions which have economic impacts, and of course impacts on individuals.
- Expert panels make policy recommendations that have social impacts.
- Research teams make scientific claims which either lead people to change their behavior or, in bad cases, to lose trust in science.
- Medical committees issue treatment guidelines that affect health outcomes.

The pooling method affects who is responsible for what.

When we are looking at when individuals are responsible for various actions, we put a lot of emphasis on belief, and on reasonable belief.

If I leave a door open, and this leads to a disaster, whether I'm responsible depends in part on whether I knew, or perhaps should have known, that a disaster was likely.

It would be very convenient if we could apply the same kind of rules of responsibility to groups, since these are very well worked out for individuals.

Two Kinds of Group Responsibility

Philosophers distinguish two kinds of responsibility.

1. **Backward-looking responsibility** is things like blame/praise for past actions. Rewards and punishment fit this.
2. **Forward-looking responsibility** is things like obligations to perform future actions.

Pooling strategies might be relevant to both.

When a group takes an action based on pooled credences, who is responsible if things go wrong? Any of the following might be plausible answers:

- The group as a whole;
- Individual members proportionally;
- Those who most influenced the pooled credence; or
- Those who should have known better.

The Equal Weight View and Responsibility

If we adopt equal weight pooling each member contributes equally to group credence, which suggests equal responsibility.

But what should we say if some members were better informed, and their credences didn't reflect the evidence. Shouldn't responsibility for bad judgments go to them.

This approach ignores epistemic asymmetries.

If we use weighted pooling, then intuitively those with higher weights bear more responsibility.

This makes sense if weights track expertise or evidence.

But maybe responsibility should go to the person who gave them more weight.

Any of you who have been part of a group decision will know that the choice of decision rule is subject to the same pressures as the decision itself. Here are some conclusions you might draw from this:

- Groups are responsible for *how* they pool opinions, not just *what* pooled credences they adopt.
- The method they adopt matters morally, not just epistemically.
- And maybe, though this is trickier, bad pooling methods can lead to unjust distributions of responsibility.

Here are some obligations you might think any group with a moderate amount of power has:

- To minimize predictable harms from their decisions;
- To use reliable information processing methods;
- To avoid systematic biases (which is related to the last point, but isn't the same);
- To be responsive to new evidence; and
- To act with appropriate care given stakes.

The pooling strategy should support these obligations.

A responsible pooling strategy should do some, ideally all, of the following things. (In any discussion of pooling, when someone says you should do all the following things, expect an impossibility theorem to follow. Maybe this won't happen here.)

- Prevent the group from making decisions they'll regret.
- Avoid wasting resources, including time spent on deliberation.
- Respect the agency and autonomy of the group members.
- Allow for appropriate deliberation and revision of beliefs.
- Be transparent and justifiable to members and outsiders. (This has become particularly important with LLMs.)

Sometimes groups face issues that individuals don't.

- Reasonable individuals might lead to unreasonable, irrational, or harmful outcomes.
- We'll see a striking example of that when we get to Schelling.
- Who is responsible when that happens? The group? Each member? No one?

Choosing a pooling strategy before the decision is made, and indeed before the credences are known, commits the group to substantive and procedural constraints.

These could have moral as well as epistemic justification.

We should not assume that the same pooling strategy is right, even when just thinking about moral responsibility, for every context. Different contexts might demand different pooling approaches:

- **High-stakes medical decisions** arguably should use conservative strategies that respect expertise.
- **Democratic deliberation** should give everyone equal voice.
- **Scientific advice** should be sensitive to track-records.
- **Emergency response** should use strategies that are not computationally intensive, and can be applied quickly.

We'll move on to looking at mathematical properties of different pooling strategies.